

FILM MAKING AND RADIO PODCASTING – CD23731
REPORT
MANANILAI

Submitted by

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BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

Certified that this report titled “MANANILAI – Film Making and Radio Podcasting CD23731” is the bonafide work of **SUGA V (231701055)** who carried out the work under my supervision. Certified further that to the best of my knowledge the work reported herein does not form part of any other thesis or dissertation on the basis of which a degree or award was conferred on an earlier occasion on this or any other candidate.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

Film making is the process of telling a story through moving images and sound. It brings together several creative and technical disciplines, including screenwriting, direction, acting, cinematography, lighting, sound recording and editing. Each of these elements shapes how the audience understands the characters, follows the events and responds emotionally to the story. A well-made film does not depend only on expensive equipment; it depends on clear ideas, careful planning and the thoughtful use of basic techniques.

A short film tells a complete story within a limited running time. Because there is very little time to establish characters and situations, every scene, line of dialogue and shot must serve a purpose. This is especially true for comedy. In a short comedy film, humour depends heavily on timing: the length of a pause, the moment a reaction is shown and the speed at which one line follows another can decide whether a joke works or falls flat.

Radio podcasting is a storytelling medium that relies entirely on sound. The listener cannot see the characters, the location or their expressions, so the story must be communicated through dialogue, narration, voice performance, sound effects, background music and silence. A podcast therefore encourages the listener to build the scene in their own imagination, which makes careful audio design essential.

The project titled “MANANILAI” is a short comedy film of approximately five to six minutes, developed as part of the Film Making and Radio Podcasting course (CD23731). The film follows two college friends, Priya and BK, who are sitting together one evening, eating snacks and scrolling through their phones. The relaxed atmosphere changes when BK suddenly asks Priya what she is going to do with her life. What follows is a conversation in which both friends try very hard to sound as if they have their futures planned, while their answers repeatedly reveal that neither of them actually knows what they are doing.

The conversation moves through five-year plans, dreams of becoming a CEO, vague plans to go abroad, questions from parents and comparisons with classmates on social media. Towards the end, it becomes briefly meaningful as the two friends accept that nobody needs to have their entire future figured out immediately. They agree to start working on their lives the next morning at 9 AM. The final scene reveals that it is already 11:47 AM and both of them are still asleep, ending the film on a light-hearted twist.

The project is designed both as a visual short film and as a story that can be adapted into an audio-only radio podcast. In the podcast version, the facial expressions, pauses and visual jokes of the film are translated into voice acting, narration, ambience and sound effects.

CHAPTER 2

PROJECT OVERVIEW

The central idea of MANANILAI is simple: two friends try to plan their future and discover that they have no plan at all. The film treats a question that many students find stressful, “What are you going to do with your life?”, and turns it into a source of relatable humour. Instead of presenting career pressure as a serious problem, the film shows how young people often respond to it with confident-sounding answers, jokes and avoidance.

The project brings together the following key ideas:

- **Friendship:** Priya and BK tease each other, question each other and laugh at each other, but they also face the same uncertainty together. Their friendship makes the conversation comfortable enough for honesty to eventually appear.
- **Uncertainty about the future:** Both characters speak about success, careers and going abroad, but none of their plans has any real detail. The gap between their confidence and their actual clarity is the foundation of the comedy.
- **Career pressure:** The repeated question from parents represents the expectations that many students experience at home. The characters admit that they tell their parents they have everything planned, even when they do not.
- **Social comparison:** A classmate’s social media profile, showing him working, travelling and buying a car, makes both friends feel that everyone else has their life sorted out.
- **Comedy:** The humour comes from dialogue, contradictions, awkward pauses, facial reactions and the difference between what the characters say and what they actually do.

The film is structured as a continuous conversation that gradually shifts in tone. It begins casually, becomes increasingly comic as each plan collapses, turns briefly reflective and then returns to comedy with the final twist. This structure allows the film to entertain the audience while still leaving them with a small but relatable message.

From a production point of view, the project is intentionally practical. It uses only two characters, a single home location and everyday objects such as mobile phones, a notebook, snacks, chairs and a table. This allows the focus to remain on performance, dialogue and comedic timing, while still providing opportunities to demonstrate camera framing, lighting, sound and editing techniques.

CHAPTER 3

TITLE – MANANILAI

The title “MANANILAI” is a Tamil word that can be understood as “state of mind” or “mental state”. It refers to how a person feels and thinks at a particular moment. The title was chosen because the film is essentially a portrait of the state of mind of two students who are unsure about their future.

On the surface, Priya and BK appear relaxed and confident. They give quick answers, make jokes and speak as if they have their lives under control. Underneath this confidence, however, their state of mind is one of confusion, mild anxiety and self-comparison. The film gradually exposes this inner state through the questions they ask each other and the answers they are unable to give.

The title also reflects the way their state of mind changes throughout the story:

- At the beginning, they are casual and distracted, eating snacks and scrolling through their phones.
- When the future is discussed, they become defensive and try to appear prepared.
- While discussing parents and social media, they feel pressure and compare themselves with others.
- In the serious moment, they become reflective and accept that it is acceptable not to have everything figured out.
- In the final scene, their state of mind is summed up in a single word: “Survive.”

The title therefore connects the comedy of the film with its underlying theme. The film is not about the careers the characters will eventually choose; it is about the mindset of young people standing at the beginning of that journey. Using a Tamil title also gives the film a local identity and makes it feel closer to the everyday experience of the students it portrays.

CHAPTER 4

GENRE

MANANILAI belongs to the comedy genre, with strong elements of friendship and slice-of-life storytelling. The film does not rely on a dramatic plot, conflict with a villain or any extraordinary event. Instead, it finds humour in an ordinary evening conversation that many students will recognise from their own lives.

As a **comedy**, the film aims to make the audience laugh through recognisable situations rather than exaggerated action. As a **friendship** film, it depends on the natural chemistry between Priya and BK, whose teasing is affectionate rather than hurtful. As a **slice-of-life** film, it presents a small, realistic moment from the lives of its characters without trying to resolve every question it raises.

The humour in MANANILAI is created through the following methods:

- **Dialogue:** Many jokes come from answers that sound confident but contain no real information, such as “First... I’ll figure out the plan” and “I’ll decide after becoming CEO.”
- **Timing:** The comedy often depends on a short pause before a line, or on how quickly a reply follows a question. The repeated “Haven’t decided” in Scene 3 works because of its rhythm.
- **Expressions:** Reactions such as BK staring at Priya, or Priya slowly nodding before saying “Strong foundation”, communicate the joke without additional words.
- **Contradictions:** The characters repeatedly claim to have a plan and then prove that they do not.
- **Relatable situations:** Questions from parents, comparing oneself with classmates online and watching motivational videos without taking action are experiences that the audience can easily identify with.

The major comic elements used in the film are:

- The sudden “dangerous question” during snack time
- A plan whose first step is to find a plan
- A five-year plan with no details
- Becoming a CEO of an undecided company
- Going abroad with no country, university or course
- Pretending to parents that everything is planned

- Three hours of success videos followed by fourteen recommended videos
- A serious 9 AM plan followed by waking up at 11:47 AM

CHAPTER 5

OBJECTIVES

The main objective of the project is to create a short, relatable comedy film using basic film-making techniques and a simple production setup. The project also aims to demonstrate how dialogue, performance, camera work, lighting, sound and editing can work together to create humour and a friendly, comfortable mood.

The specific objectives are:

- To develop an original short comedy film based on a familiar student experience.
- To practise screenplay writing and scene structuring for a short format.
- To develop natural, conversational dialogue that creates humour.
- To practise acting, especially reactions, expressions and comic timing.
- To understand cinematography, including shot types and framing for dialogue scenes.
- To use lighting effectively to create a warm and comfortable atmosphere.
- To use dialogue, ambience, sound effects and background music to support comedy.
- To practise video editing, particularly timing-based and reaction-based cutting.
- To create comedy that is relatable without being exaggerated or offensive.
- To adapt a visual story into a radio podcast format.
- To understand the differences between visual and audio storytelling.

CHAPTER 6

STORY DEVELOPMENT

The story of MANANILAI originated from a very common experience among students: being asked about the future. Parents, relatives, teachers and friends frequently ask questions such as “What are you going to do after college?” or “What are you going to do with your life?” Many students respond with answers that sound certain, even when they are still unsure. This gap between the confident answer and the uncertain reality was identified as a strong and relatable source of comedy.

The question itself was therefore made the opening line of the film. Beginning with BK asking Priya what she is going to do with her life immediately introduces the central theme and sets up the pattern that the rest of the film follows: a serious question is asked, a confident answer is given, and the answer quickly falls apart.

The story was then developed step by step, with each scene adding a new layer to the same theme:

- Scene 1 establishes that Priya claims to have a plan but does not.
- Scene 2 attempts to fix this with a formal five-year plan, which also fails.
- Scene 3 turns the question back on BK and shows that he is equally unprepared.
- Scene 4 brings in pressure from parents, which explains why both characters pretend.
- Scene 5 adds social media comparison, which makes them feel further behind.
- Scene 6 allows the conversation to become briefly honest and meaningful.
- Scene 7 undercuts that meaningful moment with the final twist.

A deliberate decision was made to keep the cast limited to two characters. Parents and the classmate are referred to in conversation but are never shown. This keeps the production simple and ensures that the entire story is carried by the relationship between Priya and BK.

Another important decision concerned the balance between comedy and meaning. The film was designed so that the reflective moment in Scene 6 feels sincere but does not become heavy or dramatic. The final twist then restores the light-hearted tone, while the closing text on screen ensures that the underlying message is not lost.

CHAPTER 7

STORY SYNOPSIS

The film opens one evening in a simple room, where two college friends, Priya and BK, are sitting casually, eating snacks and scrolling through their phones. The mood is relaxed until BK breaks the silence by asking Priya what she is going to do with her life. Priya stops eating and complains that he is asking dangerous questions while she is eating. When BK insists that everyone is planning their future, Priya claims that she already has a plan. Asked to explain it, she says that the first step is to figure out the plan. BK stares at her and sarcastically compliments her on how detailed it is.

Determined to be productive, BK dramatically picks up a notebook and suggests making a five-year plan. Priya is shocked, admitting that she does not even have a plan for tomorrow. When BK asks where she sees herself in five years, she answers that she will be rich. Asked how, she tells him that this is where he comes in. She then announces that she will be a CEO, but when BK asks what company she will lead, she pauses and replies that she will decide after becoming CEO.

Priya then turns the question on BK. He immediately becomes confident and declares that he is going abroad. However, when Priya asks which country, which university and which course, BK answers “Haven’t decided” each time. When she asks what he has actually decided, he simply says, “Abroad.” Priya slowly nods and describes it as a strong foundation.

The conversation moves to their parents, who both keep asking the same question about their future. Priya admits that she tells her parents she has everything planned, then goes to her room and searches online for how to become successful without knowing what she wants to do.

BK then opens social media and shows Priya the profile of a classmate who already appears to be working, travelling and buying a car. Both of them feel left behind. Priya confesses that she once spent three hours watching a video about the top ten ways to become successful. When BK asks whether it helped, she says no, because she went on to watch the next fourteen recommended videos.

As the laughter fades, BK asks a more serious question: what if they never figure everything out? Priya calmly replies that then they will not. She observes that everyone acts as though they have their lives figured out, but perhaps nobody actually does. Together they build a new plan: study, try things, make mistakes and somehow become successful. BK points out that this is not really a plan, and Priya replies that it is a starting point. They smile at each other.

Feeling motivated, the two friends agree to start the next day at 9 AM and shake hands dramatically to confirm the decision. The film then cuts to the next morning. The time is 11:47 AM, the phone

shows several missed alarms, and both Priya and BK are still sleeping. Half asleep, BK asks Priya what their plan is for the day. Priya answers, “Survive,” and both of them go back to sleep.

The screen cuts to black and displays the closing message: “You don’t need your whole future figured out. Just don’t sleep through it.”

CHAPTER 8

CHARACTERS

MANANILAI has only two characters. Because the entire film is a conversation, the personalities of Priya and BK and the way they react to each other are central to both the story and the comedy.

8.1 Priya

Priya is confident on the outside but uncertain about her future. She has a quick sense of humour and an answer for every question, even when that answer contains no actual plan. She acts as though she has everything figured out, and she uses jokes to avoid questions she cannot answer, such as calling BK's question "dangerous" or claiming that she will choose her company after becoming CEO.

Priya's comedy comes from her calm, casual delivery. She rarely appears embarrassed by her lack of planning, which makes her contradictions even funnier. Beneath this confidence, however, she shares the same insecurity as BK. This is revealed when she admits to searching online for how to become successful without knowing what she wants to do, and when she confesses to spending hours on motivational videos.

In the serious moment, it is Priya who expresses the central idea of the film: that everyone acts as if they have their life figured out, but perhaps nobody actually does. Her final one-word answer, "Survive," sums up her personality perfectly: honest, humorous and completely unbothered.

8.2 BK

BK is curious, thoughtful and prone to overthinking. He is the one who starts the conversation about the future and the one who pulls out a notebook to make a five-year plan. He asks serious questions and appears to want structure and direction in his life.

However, BK's own plan is just as incomplete as Priya's. He confidently announces that he is going abroad but has not decided the country, the university or the course. His comedy comes from this contradiction: he is serious about planning, yet unable to plan anything specific. He also reacts with dry sarcasm to Priya's answers, with lines such as "Wow. Very detailed" and "Excellent."

BK is also the character who is most affected by social media comparison, as he is the one who shows Priya their classmate's profile. In the reflective moment, it is BK who voices the fear of never figuring things out, which gives the film its brief emotional depth.

8.3 The Friendship Between Priya and BK

The relationship between the two characters is the heart of the film. They tease each other freely, but their teasing is always affectionate. Each of them challenges the other's plan while hiding the weakness of their own, which creates a balanced comic dynamic. By the end, they are no longer competing to seem more prepared; they are simply two friends who are equally unsure and equally comfortable admitting it to each other.

CHAPTER 9

SCENE DEVELOPMENT

The film is divided into seven scenes. Although the first six scenes take place in a single continuous conversation, each scene has a distinct focus and comic purpose. The final scene takes place the following morning.

9.1 Scene 1 – The Question

Setting: Interior of a room in the evening. Priya and BK are sitting casually, eating snacks and scrolling through their phones.

Action: The scene opens in a relaxed mood. BK looks up from his phone and asks Priya what she is going to do with her life. Priya stops eating in the middle of a bite.

BK: Priya...

PRIYA: Hmm?

BK: What are you going to do with your life?

PRIYA: Why are you asking dangerous questions while I'm eating?

Dialogue purpose: The opening question introduces the central theme immediately. Priya's claim that she has a plan, followed by "First... I'll figure out the plan", establishes the pattern of confident answers without substance.

Camera possibilities: A wide or medium two-shot can establish the room and the relaxed atmosphere. A close-up of Priya freezing mid-bite emphasises the reaction to the question, and a close-up of BK's blank stare after her answer completes the joke.

Comedy and timing: The joke depends on the short pause after "First..." and on holding BK's stare for a moment before his line "Wow. Very detailed."

Emotional progression: The mood moves from relaxed to slightly defensive as Priya is put on the spot.

Contribution to the story: This scene sets up the theme, the characters' dynamic and the comic formula that the rest of the film builds upon.

9.2 Scene 2 – The Five-Year Plan

Setting: The same room, continuing the conversation.

Action: BK dramatically grabs a notebook and suggests making a five-year plan. Priya reacts with disbelief, saying that she does not even have a plan for tomorrow.

BK: Where do you see yourself in five years?
PRIYA: Rich.
BK: How?
PRIYA: That's where you come in.

Dialogue purpose: The dialogue exposes that Priya's ambitions are goals without methods. The exchange "CEO." / "CEO of what?" followed by a long pause and "I'll decide after becoming CEO" is the main punchline of the scene.

Camera possibilities: An insert shot of the notebook and pen can emphasise BK's serious attitude. Alternating medium shots can follow the rapid question-and-answer rhythm, while a close-up can capture Priya's thinking face during the long pause.

Comedy and timing: The quick back-and-forth builds momentum, and the long pause before the final answer creates anticipation. BK's flat "Excellent." should follow without hurry.

Emotional progression: BK becomes more determined to create structure, while Priya becomes more creative in avoiding it.

Contribution to the story: The scene shows that even a formal planning method cannot help when the person has no clear direction.

9.3 Scene 3 – BK's Future

Setting: The same room, continuing the conversation.

Action: Priya turns the question back on BK, who immediately becomes confident and announces that he is going abroad. Priya questions him one detail at a time.

PRIYA: Which country?
BK: Haven't decided.
PRIYA: Which university?
BK: Haven't decided.
PRIYA: Which course?
BK: Haven't decided.
PRIYA: Then what have you decided?
BK: Abroad.

Dialogue purpose: The scene balances the story by showing that BK, who was questioning Priya, is just as unprepared. The repetition of "Haven't decided" is the comic structure of the scene.

Camera possibilities: A slight push-in or tighter framing on BK as his confidence rises can make the collapse of his plan funnier. A reaction shot of Priya slowly nodding before “Strong foundation” delivers the final beat.

Comedy and timing: The rule of repetition is used here. Each “Haven’t decided” should be delivered with the same confidence, and Priya’s sarcastic nod should be held long enough for the audience to enjoy it.

Emotional progression: BK’s confidence rises at the start of the scene and quietly collapses by the end.

Contribution to the story: The scene confirms that neither character has a real plan, making them equals in their uncertainty.

9.4 Scene 4 – Parents

Setting: The same room, continuing the conversation.

Action: BK mentions that his parents keep asking him the same question. Priya completes the question before he can say it, showing that her parents do the same. Priya then picks up her phone to demonstrate what she searches for when she is alone.

BK: What do you tell them?

PRIYA: “I have everything planned.”

BK: And then?

PRIYA: I go to my room and Google... “How to become successful without knowing what you want to do.”

Dialogue purpose: The scene explains why both characters pretend to have a plan: they are responding to expectations at home. It adds a relatable social layer to the comedy.

Camera possibilities: A two-shot captures the shared recognition when both of them say that their parents ask the same thing. A phone screen insert showing the search text can make the punchline visual.

Comedy and timing: Priya finishing BK’s sentence creates instant recognition. The search phrase should be revealed only after a brief pause so that it lands as the punchline, followed by BK’s laugh.

Emotional progression: The characters bond over a shared experience, and the mood becomes warmer and more open.

Contribution to the story: The scene shows that their confident answers are a response to outside pressure, which prepares the audience for the more honest moment later.

9.5 Scene 5 – Social Media

Setting: The same room, with the focus shifting to the phone screens.

Action: BK opens a social media app and shows Priya the profile of a classmate who appears to be working, travelling and buying a car. Priya reacts with envy, then looks at her own phone and shares her experience with motivational videos.

PRIYA: Yesterday I spent three hours watching a video called... “Top 10 ways to become successful.”

BK: Did it help?

PRIYA: No.

BK: Why?

PRIYA: I watched the next fourteen recommended videos.

Dialogue purpose: The scene introduces social comparison and shows how consuming motivational content can replace actual action.

Camera possibilities: Over-the-shoulder shots from behind BK allow the audience to see the phone and Priya’s reaction. Close-ups of the phone screen, or a short montage of the classmate’s posts, can represent his seemingly perfect life.

Comedy and timing: The contrast between the classmate’s achievements and Priya’s three hours of watching videos creates the humour. The final line should be delivered plainly, as if it were a completely reasonable explanation.

Emotional progression: The characters feel left behind, but the humour prevents this feeling from becoming heavy.

Contribution to the story: This scene provides the last layer of pressure before the conversation turns reflective.

9.6 Scene 6 – Serious Moment

Setting: The same room. The laughter from the previous scene slowly dies down.

Action: BK asks a more sincere question, and the two friends talk honestly for the first time.

BK: What if we don’t figure everything out?

PRIYA: Then we don’t.

PRIYA: Everyone acts like they have their entire life figured out. Maybe nobody actually does.

They then build a simple list together: study, try things, make mistakes and somehow become successful. BK points out that this is not a plan, and Priya replies that it is a starting point. They smile.

Dialogue purpose: The scene gives the film its message. It acknowledges the characters' uncertainty and replaces the pressure to have a complete plan with the idea of simply starting.

Camera possibilities: Slightly closer, steadier framing and a calm two-shot can signal the change in tone. Holding the shot on their smiles at the end of the scene gives the moment space.

Comedy and timing: The humour is softer here. The rhythm of Priya listing steps and BK replying "Okay" each time adds gentle humour, and "That's not a plan" / "It's a starting point" works as both a joke and a sincere line.

Emotional progression: The mood shifts from laughter to reflection and ends with quiet reassurance.

Contribution to the story: This scene provides emotional depth and sets up the plan that the final scene will humorously undo.

9.7 Scene 7 – Final Comedy

Setting: The scene begins in the same room at the end of the conversation, then cuts to the next morning at 11:47 AM.

Action: BK asks whether they will start tomorrow. Priya confirms, and they agree on 9 AM before shaking hands dramatically. The film cuts to the next morning. A phone shows the time as 11:47 AM with multiple missed alarms. Both Priya and BK are still sleeping.

BK: (half asleep) Priya...

PRIYA: Hmm?

BK: What's our plan today?

PRIYA: Survive.

They both go back to sleep. The screen cuts to black and the closing text appears.

Dialogue purpose: The final exchange mirrors the opening of the film, where BK also began with "Priya..." and Priya answered "Hmm?". The repetition creates a satisfying callback, while "Survive" replaces all the earlier ambitious plans.

Camera possibilities: A dramatic close-up of the handshake can exaggerate their seriousness. After the cut, a phone close-up showing 11:47 AM and the missed alarms reveals the joke, followed by a wide or high-angle shot of both characters asleep.

Comedy and timing: The joke depends on the contrast between the confident handshake and the sudden cut to 11:47 AM. The half-asleep dialogue should be slow and quiet, and the cut to black should come soon after “Survive” so the punchline is not diluted.

Emotional progression: The mood moves from motivated and determined to sleepy and defeated, returning the film to pure comedy.

Contribution to the story: The scene delivers the climax and the final message of the film.

CHAPTER 10

CLIMAX AND ENDING

The climax of MANANILAI is built on the gap between intention and action. After an entire conversation of failed plans, the two friends finally reach an honest starting point in Scene 6. They commit to beginning the next day at exactly 9 AM and seal the decision with a dramatic handshake. For a moment, the audience is led to believe that the characters have genuinely changed.

The film then cuts directly to the next morning. The phone shows 11:47 AM along with several missed alarms, and both friends are still asleep. The humour of the climax comes from this sudden reversal: the one concrete decision they made in the entire film, the time to start, is the first thing they fail at.

The final dialogue deliberately repeats the opening of the film. BK begins with “Priya...” and Priya replies “Hmm?”, just as in Scene 1. This time, however, BK’s question is no longer about their whole life but only about the day ahead. Priya’s answer, “Survive,” reduces all the earlier talk of wealth, CEOs and going abroad to a single, honest word. Both characters then go back to sleep, showing that nothing has changed and that they are completely at peace with it.

The ending is closed with a text card on a black screen: “You don’t need your whole future figured out. Just don’t sleep through it.” This message serves two purposes. It completes the joke by referring directly to the characters sleeping through their plan, and it restates the gentle lesson of the film. The first sentence reassures the audience that uncertainty is normal, while the second reminds them that action still matters.

The ending therefore balances comedy and meaning. The audience laughs at the characters’ failure, but also recognises a small part of themselves in it.

CHAPTER 11

CINEMATOGRAPHY

Cinematography in MANANILAI is designed to support conversation and comedy. Since most of the film consists of two people talking in one location, the choice of shots and the rhythm between them are important for keeping the film visually interesting and for landing each joke clearly.

- **Wide shots:** A wide shot at the beginning establishes the room, the snacks, the phones and the relaxed positions of the two characters. A wide shot is also useful in the final scene to show both friends asleep at 11:47 AM.
- **Medium shots:** Medium shots form the base of most conversation scenes, showing each character's face, body language and actions such as eating, holding the phone or writing in the notebook.
- **Close-ups:** Close-ups capture the key comic expressions, such as Priya freezing mid-bite, BK's blank stare and Priya's thinking face before "I'll decide after becoming CEO."
- **Two-shots:** Two-shots show both characters together and are important for moments of shared reaction, such as realising that their parents ask the same question, and for the smile at the end of Scene 6.
- **Over-the-shoulder shots:** These shots are useful when one character asks a question and the camera shows the other character's response, as in the rapid questioning of BK in Scene 3, and when BK shows Priya the phone in Scene 5.
- **Phone close-ups:** Close-ups of the phone screen show the social media profile, the search text and the time of 11:47 AM with missed alarms. These shots deliver information that is part of the joke.
- **Reaction shots:** Many punchlines in the film work through reactions rather than words. Cutting to the listener's face after a line, such as Priya's slow nod before "Strong foundation", is essential for comic effect.
- **Static camera during conversations:** A mostly static camera, placed on a tripod or held steady, keeps the conversation natural and allows the performances to carry the scene without distraction.
- **Slight camera variation for comedic timing:** Occasional changes, such as a slightly tighter frame on BK when he confidently says "I'm going abroad" or a sudden close-up on the handshake, can emphasise a comic beat without becoming excessive.

The overall aim of the cinematography is to keep the film simple, clear and natural, while using framing and shot selection to highlight the moments that create humour.

CHAPTER 12

LIGHTING

Since MANANILAI is a light-hearted comedy, the lighting is designed to be natural, soft and comfortable. The goal is to create an inviting atmosphere that makes the audience feel as though they are sitting in the room with two friends.

The evening conversation can be lit using soft room lighting, such as ceiling lights or table lamps, which makes the space feel warm and homely. Soft light reduces harsh shadows on the characters' faces, which is important because facial expressions are a major source of comedy in the film. Harsh, dark or high-contrast lighting would create a dramatic or tense mood that does not suit the story.

Consistency is another important consideration. Because Scenes 1 to 6 form one continuous conversation, the lighting should remain the same throughout so that the scenes cut together smoothly. If the film is shot on a terrace or near a window, changes in daylight during the shoot can affect continuity, so shooting within a consistent time window or relying mainly on room lights is preferable.

The phone screens can provide a small amount of light on the characters' faces while they scroll, adding realism without becoming the main light source.

The final scene at 11:47 AM can use brighter natural daylight, for example sunlight entering through a window or curtains. This contrast with the warm evening lighting of the earlier scenes immediately tells the audience that time has passed and that the characters have slept well into the late morning, which strengthens the final joke.

CHAPTER 13

SOUND DESIGN

Sound design in MANANILAI supports the comedy and keeps the atmosphere relaxed and friendly. Because the film is driven by conversation, clear dialogue is the most important sound element. Other sounds are used to add realism and to emphasise comic moments without overpowering the performances.

- **Dialogue:** Every line must be clear and audible, as most of the humour depends on the exact wording and delivery.
- **Room ambience:** A quiet background room tone, such as a ceiling fan or faint outside noise, makes the space feel real and helps smooth cuts between shots.
- **Snack sounds:** The crunch of snacks and the rustle of a packet establish the casual mood at the beginning of the film.
- **Phone sounds:** Scrolling, tapping and typing sounds support the moments when the characters use their phones, particularly the search in Scene 4 and the social media scene.
- **Notification sounds:** Occasional notification tones can add realism to the phone-scrolling moments and can be timed to punctuate a line.
- **Small comedic sound effects:** Subtle effects, such as a pen click when BK opens the notebook or a light sound on the dramatic handshake, can highlight a joke. These should be used sparingly so the humour remains natural.
- **Background music:** Light, playful background music can be used in transitions and at low volume under the conversation. A softer, gentler tone suits Scene 6, and a cheerful cue can accompany the end card.
- **Alarm sound:** An alarm sound, or the suggestion of repeatedly missed alarms, introduces the final scene and helps establish that the characters have overslept.
- **Silence and pauses:** Silence is used as a comic tool. Removing music before a punchline, or allowing a pause to hang before “I’ll decide after becoming CEO”, gives the joke more impact.

The sound design deliberately avoids tense or dramatic effects. Every sound choice is intended to keep the film light, warm and easy to enjoy.

CHAPTER 14

EDITING TECHNIQUES

Editing is one of the most important stages in a comedy film because the timing of a cut directly affects whether a joke works. In MANANILAI, editing is used to maintain the rhythm of the conversation and to control when the audience sees each reaction.

- **Straight cuts:** Simple straight cuts between shots keep the conversation flowing naturally and avoid drawing attention to the editing.
- **Reaction cuts:** Cutting to one character's reaction immediately after the other speaks is essential to the humour, for example cutting to BK's stare after "First... I'll figure out the plan."
- **Jump cuts:** Jump cuts can be used where appropriate, such as during the rapid "Haven't decided" sequence or to compress Priya's three hours of watching videos into a few seconds.
- **Timing-based editing:** The length of each pause is adjusted in the edit. Holding a shot slightly longer before a punchline builds anticipation, while cutting quickly after it keeps the energy up.
- **Phone screen inserts:** Shots of the phone screen, including the search text, the classmate's profile and the 11:47 AM time display, are inserted at the exact moment they support the dialogue.
- **Text overlays:** Text can be used where required, such as a "NEXT MORNING" caption, the time on screen and the closing message on the black end card.
- **Montage for social media:** A short, quick montage of the classmate's posts showing work, travel and a new car can exaggerate his apparently perfect life in a few seconds.
- **Cut to the 11:47 AM scene:** The most important edit in the film is the direct cut from the dramatic handshake to the next morning. No transition is used, so the contrast between their promise and their reality is immediate and funny.

The overall editing approach is simple and clean. The focus is on pacing, reactions and precise timing rather than on heavy visual effects.

CHAPTER 15

USE OF PROPS AND LOCATION

MANANILAI is designed to be produced with a single, simple home location and everyday props. This makes the project practical and low-budget while keeping attention on the characters and dialogue.

The primary location can be a bedroom, a living room or a terrace. Any of these spaces suits the story because they are places where college friends naturally sit together and talk. An indoor room offers better control over lighting and sound, while a terrace can add a relaxed, open feel if natural light and outdoor noise are managed carefully. The final scene requires a place where both characters can plausibly be shown asleep, such as the same room.

The props used in the film and their purposes are listed below.

Prop	Purpose in the Film
Mobile phones	Scrolling at the start, searching online in Scene 4, the classmate's social media profile in Scene 5, and the 11:47 AM time with missed alarms in Scene 7
Notebook and pen	Used by BK to make the five-year plan, showing his serious attitude towards planning
Snacks	Establish the casual mood and allow Priya's comic reaction when she stops eating
Chairs	Seating for the conversation scenes
Table	Holds the snacks, phones and notebook, and anchors the composition of the two-shots
Laptop (if required)	Can be used as an alternative screen for viewing videos or social media, if it suits the setting

The limited number of props keeps the production simple while still giving each scene a clear visual focus.

CHAPTER 16

RADIO PODCAST ADAPTATION

MANANILAI can be adapted into an audio-only comedy podcast. The story, characters and dialogue remain the same, but every piece of visual information must now be communicated through sound. This is a particular challenge for a comedy, since many jokes in the film depend on facial expressions, reaction shots and what is shown on a phone screen.

To solve this, the visual comedy is converted into audio techniques:

- **Voice acting:** Emotions and reactions that were visible on screen are expressed through tone of voice, such as a sarcastic “Wow. Very detailed” or a proud “I’m going abroad.”
- **Dialogue:** Small additions to the dialogue can make actions clear, for example a character reading out what is on the phone.
- **Narration:** A narrator describes the setting, the time and actions that cannot be heard, such as the handshake or the characters sleeping.
- **Pauses:** Pauses replace reaction shots. A silence after a line lets the listener imagine the other character’s expression.
- **Background ambience:** Room tone and evening sounds place the listener in the room; morning sounds signal the time jump.
- **Sound effects:** Snack crunching, notebook pages and a pen click represent the physical actions in the story.
- **Phone sounds:** Scrolling, typing and notification sounds represent phone use.
- **Alarm sound:** Repeated alarms that are switched off or ignored create the final joke in audio form.

The following table shows how key visual moments from the film are translated into audio.

Visual Moment in the Film	Audio Equivalent in the Podcast
Priya freezes mid-bite	Crunching stops abruptly, followed by a short silence
BK stares at Priya after her plan	A deliberate pause before BK’s sarcastic reply
BK grabs the notebook dramatically	Pages flipping and a pen click, with an eager tone
Priya slowly nods: “Strong foundation”	A drawn-out “Hmm...” before the line
Phone screen showing the search text	Typing sounds while Priya reads the search aloud
Classmate’s social media profile	Scrolling sounds while BK describes the posts

Visual Moment in the Film	Audio Equivalent in the Podcast
Dramatic handshake	A firm clap-like handshake sound and brief upbeat music
Clock showing 11:47 AM with missed alarms	Alarm sounds snoozed repeatedly, then narration of the time
Both characters asleep	Soft breathing or snoring with quiet morning ambience
End card text	Narrator reads the closing message

This adaptation demonstrates how the same comedy can be experienced through imagination instead of sight.

CHAPTER 17

RADIO PODCAST SCRIPT APPROACH

The podcast version of MANANILAI uses three voices: a NARRATOR, PRIYA and BK. The narrator is used only where necessary, to set the scene, describe important actions and mark the change of time. Most of the story is told through the dialogue itself, supported by sound effects and music. Sound cues are written in square brackets.

The narration is kept short and light in tone so that it does not interrupt the comic rhythm. Pauses are written into the script wherever a reaction would have been shown in the film. The script below presents the complete audio version of the story.

17.1 Podcast Script – MANANILAI

[Light, playful music fades in and lowers. Room ambience. A ceiling fan hums. Snack packet rustles. Crunching.]

NARRATOR: An ordinary evening. Two friends, Priya and BK, are sitting together with a packet of snacks and their phones. Nobody is doing anything important. Until BK asks a question.

BK: Priya...

PRIYA: (mouth full) Hmm?

BK: What are you going to do with your life?

[Crunching stops. Short silence.]

PRIYA: Why are you asking dangerous questions while I'm eating?

BK: I'm serious. Everyone is planning their future.

PRIYA: I have a plan.

BK: Really? What's the plan?

PRIYA: First... I'll figure out the plan.

[Pause.]

BK: (flat) Wow. Very detailed.

[Pages flipping. Pen click.]

NARRATOR: BK grabs a notebook. He means business.

BK: Okay. Let's make a five-year plan.

PRIYA: Five years?! I don't even have a plan for tomorrow.

BK: Just answer. Where do you see yourself in five years?

PRIYA: Rich.

BK: How?

PRIYA: That's where you come in.

BK: What job?

PRIYA: CEO.

BK: CEO of what?

[Long pause. Fan hums.]

PRIYA: I'll decide after becoming CEO.

BK: Excellent.

PRIYA: Okay, enough about me. What's YOUR plan?

BK: (proudly) I'm going abroad.

PRIYA: Nice! Which country?

BK: Haven't decided.

PRIYA: Which university?

BK: Haven't decided.

PRIYA: Which course?

BK: Haven't decided.

PRIYA: Then what have you decided?

BK: Abroad.

PRIYA: (slowly) Hmm... Strong foundation.

BK: Actually, my parents keep asking me the same question.

PRIYA: "What are you going to do with your life?"

BK: Exactly!

PRIYA: Mine too.

BK: What do you tell them?

PRIYA: "I have everything planned."

BK: And then?

[Phone unlocking. Typing.]

PRIYA: I go to my room and Google... "How to become successful without knowing what you want to do."

[BK laughs.]

[Scrolling sounds. A notification tone.]

BK: Look at this guy. Our classmate. He's already working, travelling, buying a car...

PRIYA: Damn.

PRIYA: Yesterday I spent three hours watching a video called... "Top 10 ways to become successful."

BK: Did it help?

PRIYA: No.

BK: Why?

PRIYA: I watched the next fourteen recommended videos.

[Laughter fades. Music softens into a gentle tune.]

BK: But seriously, Priya... what if we don't figure everything out?

PRIYA: Then we don't.

BK: That's it?

PRIYA: Everyone acts like they have their entire life figured out. (pause) Maybe nobody actually does.

BK: So what's our plan?

PRIYA: Study.

BK: Okay.

PRIYA: Try things.

BK: Okay.

PRIYA: Make mistakes.

BK: Okay.

PRIYA: And somehow become successful.

BK: That's not a plan.

PRIYA: It's a starting point.

NARRATOR: For the first time all evening, neither of them is pretending.

BK: So... tomorrow we'll start?

PRIYA: Definitely.

BK: What time?

PRIYA: 9 AM.

BK: Perfect.

[A firm handshake sound. A short, triumphant music sting. Music cuts out.]

[Silence. Then birds and faint morning street sounds. A phone alarm rings and is snoozed. It rings again and is snoozed again.]

NARRATOR: The next morning. The time is 11:47 AM. Both of them are still asleep.

[Soft breathing. A pillow shuffles.]

BK: (half asleep) Priya...

PRIYA: (half asleep) Hmm?

BK: What's our plan today?

PRIYA: Survive.

[Blanket rustles. Snoring resumes. Pause.]

NARRATOR: You don't need your whole future figured out. Just don't sleep through it.
[Playful music rises and fades out.]

CHAPTER 18

VOICE AND AUDIO PERFORMANCE

Voice performance is especially important in the podcast version of MANANILAI because the listener cannot see any expressions. The personality of each character, and much of the comedy, must be communicated entirely through the voice. The delivery for all characters should feel natural and conversational rather than theatrical, as if the listener is overhearing two real friends.

18.1 Priya

Priya's voice should be confident, casual and humorous. She speaks with relaxed ease, even when her answers make no sense, and she should never sound embarrassed. Lines such as "I'll decide after becoming CEO" and "Survive" should be delivered calmly and matter-of-factly, because her unbothered tone is what makes them funny. In the serious moment, her voice can soften slightly to show sincerity without becoming dramatic.

18.2 BK

BK's voice should be curious, slightly overthinking and conversational. He sounds earnest when asking questions and eager when he starts the five-year plan. His sarcastic lines, such as "Wow. Very detailed" and "Excellent", should be delivered dryly. When he announces "I'm going abroad", his voice should be full of pride, which makes each "Haven't decided" more amusing. In Scene 6, a quieter, more hesitant tone conveys his genuine concern.

18.3 Narrator

The narrator should sound friendly and lightly amused, as if gently observing the two friends. The narration should be brief and clearly paced, and should never compete with the characters for attention.

18.4 Key Performance Elements

- Clear pronunciation so that every word of a punchline is understood
- Natural, conversational delivery instead of exaggerated acting
- Well-placed pauses to replace visual reactions
- Distinct voices so that listeners can easily tell Priya and BK apart
- Controlled pace: quick exchanges for comic rhythm, slower delivery for the serious moment
- Sleepy, low-energy delivery in the final scene

- Background music kept low so that dialogue remains clear

CHAPTER 19

PRODUCTION PROCESS

The production of MANANILAI can be divided into three stages: pre-production, production and post-production.

19.1 Pre-production

During pre-production, the story idea was developed from the common experience of students being asked about their future. The idea was converted into a screenplay of seven scenes with two characters, Priya and BK, and a planned running time of approximately five to six minutes. The location, props and required sound effects were identified. The comic beats of each scene, including the important pauses and reactions, were planned so that the humour would build steadily towards the final twist. The podcast script was also prepared by adapting the screenplay for audio.

19.2 Production

During production, the scenes are recorded according to the screenplay. Since the first six scenes form one continuous conversation, the dialogue can be recorded in longer takes to maintain natural flow, and then repeated from different angles to provide wide shots, medium shots, close-ups and reaction shots for editing. Phone screen shots and insert shots, such as the notebook and the handshake, are recorded separately. The final 11:47 AM scene is recorded with brighter lighting to show that it is the next morning. Voice recordings for the podcast version are carried out in a quiet space to obtain clean audio.

19.3 Post-production

During post-production, the recorded footage is reviewed and organised by scene. The best takes are selected and arranged according to the screenplay. Reaction shots and phone inserts are placed to support the timing of each joke, and pauses are trimmed or extended as needed. Room ambience, sound effects, background music and the alarm sound are added and balanced with the dialogue. Text overlays and the final end card are included. For the podcast, the voice recordings are edited together with narration, ambience and sound effects. The complete film and podcast are reviewed before being exported in their final form.

CHAPTER 20

CHALLENGES FACED

Although MANANILAI is a simple production, creating a comedy that feels natural and well-timed presents several challenges.

- **Maintaining natural dialogue:** The conversation must sound like two real friends talking, not like actors reciting lines. Achieving a casual, unforced delivery requires rehearsal and comfort between the performers.
- **Getting comedic timing right:** A pause that is slightly too short or too long can weaken a joke. Finding the right timing for lines such as “I’ll decide after becoming CEO” requires several takes and careful editing.
- **Avoiding repetitive shots:** Since the film is largely two people sitting and talking, there is a risk that the visuals become monotonous. Varying shot sizes and angles while keeping the style natural is necessary to maintain visual interest.
- **Maintaining continuity:** Because the conversation is continuous, details such as the amount of snacks, the position of the phones, the notebook and the characters’ posture must remain consistent across shots.
- **Recording clean audio:** In a home environment, background noise from fans, traffic or other household sounds can interfere with dialogue. Clear audio is essential because the humour depends on every word being heard.
- **Synchronising dialogue and actions:** Actions such as stopping mid-bite, opening the notebook or showing the phone must happen exactly with the relevant lines for the joke to work.
- **Creating humour without excessive effects:** The film aims for natural comedy. Using too many sound effects or visual effects could make the humour feel forced, so restraint is required.
- **Shooting in a limited location:** A single room offers limited visual variety, so framing, lighting and composition must be used creatively to keep the film engaging.
- **Translating visual comedy into audio:** For the podcast, jokes that depend on expressions must be rewritten or performed so that they work through sound alone.

CHAPTER 21

LEARNING OUTCOMES

Working on MANANILAI provided practical experience across the major stages of film making and radio podcasting. The key learning outcomes are as follows.

- **Screenwriting:** I learned how to write short, natural dialogue in which each line either develops the characters or delivers a joke, and how to structure a script into clear scenes.
- **Story development:** I learned how an ordinary, everyday experience can be developed into a complete story, and how each scene can add a new layer to one central theme.
- **Acting:** I learned that comedy often depends more on reactions and expressions than on the lines themselves, and that natural delivery is more effective than exaggerated performance.
- **Camera framing:** I learned how to use wide shots, medium shots, close-ups, two-shots, over-the-shoulder shots and inserts to make a dialogue-based scene visually engaging.
- **Lighting:** I learned how soft, natural lighting creates a comfortable mood and how a change in lighting can communicate a change in time.
- **Sound recording:** I learned the importance of recording clean dialogue and how ambience, sound effects and music support the mood of a scene.
- **Editing:** I learned how reaction cuts, jump cuts and precise timing shape the effectiveness of a joke, and how a single direct cut can create a strong comic twist.
- **Comedy timing:** I learned that pauses, repetition, callbacks and contrast are powerful tools in comedy, and that silence can be as effective as a line of dialogue.
- **Radio podcast production:** I learned how to adapt visual storytelling for audio, using narration, voice performance, pauses and sound effects to help the listener imagine what they cannot see.

Overall, the project demonstrated how the same story must be approached differently depending on whether it is seen or only heard.

CHAPTER 22

EXPECTED OUTCOME

The final outcome of the project is a short comedy film titled MANANILAI, of approximately five to six minutes, supported by a radio podcast adaptation of the same story.

The short film is expected to present a natural, light-hearted conversation between two college friends that audiences, particularly students, can immediately relate to. It is expected to create humour through dialogue, timing, expressions and contradictions, and to build towards a memorable final twist in which the characters sleep through their own 9 AM plan. The closing message is expected to leave viewers smiling while also reminding them that it is acceptable to be uncertain about the future, as long as they keep moving forward.

The radio podcast is expected to deliver the same story and humour entirely through sound. Listeners should be able to follow the conversation, picture the characters' reactions and enjoy the final joke through voice performance, narration, ambience and sound effects alone.

Together, the film and the podcast are expected to demonstrate the practical application of screenwriting, acting, cinematography, lighting, sound design, editing and audio storytelling techniques learned in the course.

CHAPTER 23

CONCLUSION

MANANILAI demonstrates how a simple, everyday situation can be developed into an engaging and relatable short comedy film. The story begins with a single question, “What are you going to do with your life?”, and uses it to explore the uncertainty, pressure and self-comparison that many students experience. Through Priya and BK, the film shows that confident answers often hide confusion, and that this confusion is both common and understandable.

The project combines screenwriting, acting, cinematography, lighting, sound design and editing. Each element contributes to the comedy: the dialogue creates contradictions, the performances deliver the reactions, the camera captures the key expressions, the lighting keeps the mood warm and friendly, and the editing controls the timing of every joke. The use of two characters and a single location also shows that an effective short film does not require complex resources.

At its heart, MANANILAI is a film about friendship and student life. Priya and BK begin by trying to appear more prepared than each other and end by admitting, together, that they are both unsure. The final twist at 11:47 AM keeps the tone light, while the closing message gives the film its lasting meaning.

The radio podcast adaptation further demonstrates how a visual comedy can be translated into an audio experience. Expressions, reactions and on-screen information are communicated through voice performance, narration, pauses, ambience and sound effects.

Overall, MANANILAI provides practical experience in both film making and radio podcasting while demonstrating the importance of timing, performance and relatable storytelling in comedy.

“You don’t need your whole future figured out. Just don’t sleep through it.”